

Psalms 41

Blessed Considereth the Poor

Blessed is he that considereth the poor

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Blessed is he that considereth the poor: the LORD will deliver him in time of trouble.*
- 2 *The LORD will preserve him, and keep him alive; and he shall be blessed upon the earth: and thou wilt not deliver him unto the will of his enemies.*
- 3 *The LORD will strengthen him upon the bed of languishing: thou wilt make all his bed in his sickness.*
- 4 *I said, LORD, be merciful unto me: heal my soul; for I have sinned against thee.*
- 5 *Mine enemies speak evil of me, When shall he die, and his name perish?*
- 6 *And if he come to see me, he speaketh vanity: his heart gathereth iniquity to itself; when he goeth abroad, he telleth it.*
- 7 *All that hate me whisper together against me: against me do they devise my hurt.*
- 8 *An evil disease, say they, cleaveth fast unto him: and now that he lieth he shall rise up no more.*
- 9 *Yea, mine own familiar friend, in whom I trusted, which did eat of my bread, hath lifted up his heel against me.*
- 10 *But thou, O LORD, be merciful unto me, and raise me up, that I may requite them.*
- 11 *By this I know that thou favourest me, because mine enemy doth not triumph over me.*
- 12 *And as for me, thou upholdest me in mine integrity, and settest me before thy face for ever.*
- 13 *Blessed be the LORD God of Israel from everlasting, and to everlasting. Amen, and Amen.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 41 opens with a beatitude on compassionate care for the weak, promising that God reciprocally cares for the compassionate in their own trouble and sickness, then turns into a lament over betrayal by a close, trusted friend who ate the psalmist's bread yet "lifted up his heel" against him—words Jesus later applies to Judas' betrayal (John 13:18). It closes Book I of the Psalter with a doxology of praise. Henry links mercy shown to the weak with mercy needed from God when one is weak, and notes that betrayal by an intimate carries a unique sting that God still sees and answers.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

Blessed is the one who considers the poor; the Lord will deliver him in time of trouble, preserve him, keep him alive, and bless him on the earth, not delivering him to the will of his enemies. The Lord will strengthen him on the bed of languishing and make all his bed in sickness.

Verse 4-6

David turns to his own need, confessing, "I have sinned against thee," while his enemies speak evil of him and wish for his death, speaking vain, hollow words when they come to see him.

Verse 7-9

Whisperers devise hurt against him, imagining he has some evil disease that will finish him. Even his own close, familiar friend, in whom he trusted and who ate his bread, has lifted up his heel against him.

Verse 10-13

He asks for mercy and to be raised up so he can requite them, assured his enemy will not ultimately triumph over him; he is upheld in his integrity and set before God's face forever. The chapter—and Book I of the Psalter—closes with a doxology: "Blessed be the Lord God of Israel from everlasting to everlasting. Amen, and Amen."

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Compassion shown to the weak and vulnerable is not sentimental extra credit—it is the pattern by which God Himself relates to us, and He notices and answers those who practice it. Betrayal by someone deeply trusted is one of life's sharpest pains, but it does not escape God's sight or His ultimate justice.

Application for life today.

Identify a concrete way to “consider the poor” this week—not as charity in the abstract but as attentive, personal care for someone specific. If you have been betrayed by a close friend, let this psalm validate that particular grief rather than minimizing it, and bring it honestly to God as David does. Practice the psalm’s honesty in verse 4—naming your own sin alongside the wrong done to you, rather than only the wrong done by others.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Who is someone vulnerable near you that you could “consider” concretely and personally this week, following verse 1?

2. Have you experienced the particular pain of betrayal by a trusted friend (v. 9), and how does knowing Christ endured this too shape your response?

3. How does the doxology closing Book I (v. 13) invite you to end even a hard prayer with praise rather than only petition?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).